

THE YOGI MAHAKUMBH

A CONFLUENCE OF FAITH

Fresh off the success of the 2025 Mahakumbh in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath was at his buoyant best at the India Today Conclave, speaking at length on several issues, including the mega event and the criticism around it. Calling the grand congregation a testament to unity and discipline, he explained how the holy dip had played the great leveller, erased differences such as rich-poor or that between castes. "The so-called seculars alleged that there is discrimination in the Sanatan tradition, but the Mahakumbh has put a stop to that, for everyone was bathing in the same sangam.... The Kumbh gave a message of unity, and it was there for everyone to see."

The CM elaborated on the extensive planning behind the Mahakumbh, highlighting how his administration had spatially budgeted for 400-450 million devotees but ended up seeing much higher numbers. On the tragic stampede on Mauni Amavasya which took many lives, he emphasised how the government's swift response and foresight had saved thousands more. "There were 40 million pilgrims in the area, another 40 million were expected during the day and from 4 am, the *amrit snan* of the *akharas* was planned. Our first responsibility was to take the injured to hospital through the green corridors. We achieved that within 15 minutes. We also wanted to ensure that there was no panic. The first rule of crisis management is to take care of the survivors and provide critical medical attention to those injured. We fulfilled both duties. We will now wait for the commission report on what went wrong, and take action based on that," Yogi said.

High polemic on controversial matters is an expected flavour from him, and Yogi didn't disappoint. On Samajwadi Party MLA Abu Azmi's statement hailing Aurangzeb, he said, "If someone considers Aurangzeb their idol, he must be suffering from a mental disorder.... It was Aurangzeb who got the Kashi Vishwanath temple demolished, razed the Sri Krishna temple in Mathura, imposed jaziya tax on Hindus. He played with the faith of India. In Uttar Pradesh, we have the best treatment for people who give such statements." Again, on the Sambhal Juma Masjid issue, the CM claimed the place is mentioned in the Puranas. "There was no Islam at that time, but our Puranas say that the 10th incarnation of Lord Vishnu (Kalki) will be in Sambhal. These are places of pilgrimage that were plundered and destroyed.... Now the ASI is doing a survey based on court orders," he said.

The take-no-prisoners stand continued on matters like Holi celebrations and, of course, the UP assembly election in 2027, which Yogi framed as a contest between the 80 per cent and the 20 per cent. So the predictions are in: another win for the saffron side. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **450 million people were expected for the Mahakumbh, but some 660 mn took the holy dip instead, says UP govt**
- **For the first time, people from the South and even the Northeast actively participated in the Mahakumbh**
- **Religious tourism has taken off in UP. The govt has created five 'spiritual corridors' for the benefit of devotees**
- **Heritage and development have to go hand in hand. If you don't consider India's traditions ideal, it'll be a barrier to development**
- **Sambhal is a reality, the mosque was built over a temple. The 10th incarnation of Vishnu will appear here**

To watch the full session, visit **https://bitly.cx/fkzGq**

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**